choices can be straddled or sidestepped. This is particularly so in respect of the digital domain and critical and emerging technologies. And while engaged in that exercise, the global scenario itself must also be clinically assessed from our perspective. Convergences and contradictions can be systemic in certain domains.

Developing affinities with the West will definitely pay well in the era of the knowledge economy. It is, therefore, crucial that we approach the larger issue as much with our heads as with our hearts. Eventually, new compacts will come into being that could more accurately reflect rebalancing and multipolarity.

The attention that the Modi government has devoted to building ties with Europe is a significant departure from the passivity of the preceding decades. Earlier, Indian diplomacy mostly concentrated on larger states, especially the UK, France and Germany. This continues to a certain degree, but there is now a more sustained focus on the EU as a collective body, and also sub-regions and smaller states. Regular India–EU summits have done much to change the atmosphere, leading to the resumption of FTA negotiations.

For India, Germany is clearly the account where there is visible space for further growth. Till now, much of that country's attention has been on other parts of Asia. That could well change somewhat in the light of new strategic circumstances. Indeed, it is the progress with the India–Germany relationship which could make the difference with that of the EU as a whole.

Among the sub-regions, the Nordic engagement has been particularly prominent, delivering results in the political and economic domains. The Mediterranean one, including Italy and Greece, has been less collective but still enthusiastic and impactful. It could acquire a new significance in the context of IMEC. The MMPA with Portugal was particularly timely in catalysing the rest of the EU.

Reinforcing relations with Central and Eastern Europe remains a work in progress, and different formats are being explored. Indian energies have also been expended in the Baltic and the Caucasus, including through the opening of embassies.

Handling the East–West contradiction is today one of the major challenges for Indian diplomacy. But the East is not a simple proposition for India. After the first decade of Independence, that has never been India's